

Anurag Thakur
Minister of Youth Affairs & Sports and Minister of Information & Broadcasting

INFORMATION & BROADCASTING

IN THE SECOND TERM of the Narendra Modi government, the ministry of information and broadcasting has been in the news mostly for all the wrong reasons. There were massive showdowns between the government and big tech companies. A new law was enacted to prevent the proliferation of misinformation and misuse of social media and OTT platforms. A TV channel was banned for allegedly hurting national security interests and several YouTube channels blocked for their alleged anti-India content. Critics and rival political parties called these moves government censorship.

Worse, India was ranked 142 among 180 countries in the World Press Freedom Index compiled by Reporters without Borders in 2021. Dismissing this ranking by a "foreign Non-Government Organisation", I&B minister Anurag Thakur said that the findings were based on a very small sample size, a questionable and non-transparent methodology was adopted and there was lack of a clear definition of press freedom. But beyond the high-decibel debates, the ministry took several positive steps such as preserving and digitising regional films and constituting a committee to review existing guidelines on the Journalist Welfare Scheme. ■

WORK DONE

- 20 documentary films, three feature films and four shorts produced in regional languages; 300 regional documentaries and 150 regional films screened
- A total of 48,445 films, including shorts, digitised or restored under a conservation project
- 1,400 feature films digitised, another 382 restored
- 120,000 DTH set top boxes distributed in remote, tribal and Left-Wing Extremism (LWE)-affected areas
- 17 per cent increase in coverage area of FM terrestrial transmission
- Constituted committee in Sept. 2021 to review existing guidelines of the Journalists Welfare Scheme and to make appropriate recommendations

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Create a mechanism to curb fake news and misinformation without hurting freedom of speech
- Prevent Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, from becoming a tool for censorship by the government machinery
- Implement the recommendations of the Justice Mudgal Committee of 2013 to amend the Cinematograph Act of 1952, which governs film certification in India
- Enact laws in Parliament to ensure safe working environment for journalists